

AIRCRAFT GO TO WAR

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AIRCRAFT FOUND THEIR FIRST PRACTICAL USE as instruments of war. Between 1914 and 1918, aviation matured under the stress of combat. For the first time, aircraft were operated on a daily basis, with all that implies of regular servicing and a focus on reliability. More powerful engines and sturdier airframes brought a great leap forward in overall performance.

There was also a change of scale: aircraft had been manufactured in hundreds before the war; now they were produced in thousands. Militarily, the Great War saw the identification of the different roles aircraft could perform and the design of specialized aircraft to fulfill them – including bombers, which would develop after the war into the first airliners. The air aces who fought above the Western Front consolidated the tradition of pilots as popular heroes.



ON PATROL

A B.E.2c of the Royal Flying Corps flies over trenches in Belgium during World War I. The B.E.2c entered the war at a time when the future role of aircraft was unclear. Eventually it was used as a reconnaissance plane, a light bomber, and a home defense fighter against dirigibles.